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India: Between “Strategic Autonomy” and “Geopolitical Opportunity”

C. Raja Mohan

The U.S. rebalancing strategy toward Asia announced by the Obama administration has been long overdue. Despite the end of the Cold War in Europe, policy inertia in Washington meant that a large portion of U.S. military resources continued to be deployed in the Atlantic. This imbalance was further exacerbated by the two prolonged and costly military deployments in Iraq and Afghanistan. A new consensus also prevailed in Washington that there was no potential great-power peer competitor to the United States and that it thus had the luxury of experimenting with nation-building and democracy-promotion in the Middle East and beyond. The costly interventions in Iraq and Afghanistan have disabused many in the U.S. foreign policy establishment of their post-Cold War beliefs about the efficacy of American power in changing the world for good. They have instead been persuaded that it is time for the United States to look after its own vital national interests.

Moreover, the U.S. diplomatic and military pivot to Asia had been delayed by a misreading of China’s intentions toward the United States over the years. Many in the United States were quite convinced that the rise of China was likely to be peaceful and that China could, with some purposeful U.S. effort, be integrated into the current international system. This assumption, however, became untenable after President Obama’s unsuccessful visit to China in November 2009. Beijing, which seemed to have concluded that the United States was on an irreversible path of decline, had no interest in Washington’s strategic reassurance or its offers to jointly manage the problems of the world. Worse still, China’s military and political assertiveness during 2009–11 demanded urgent responses from the Obama administration. Any further delay in announcing the pivot would have weakened U.S. alliances in Asia and raised the threat of China’s successful “Finlandization” of the continent’s rimland. The tension between China’s growing military capabilities and the sustainability of the U.S. military’s forward presence in Asia would have

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emerged sooner or later. That there has been little partisan criticism of the Obama administration's new approach to Asia underlines the current understanding within the U.S. political class on the imperative of dealing with the rising power of China.

Implications for Indo-U.S. Relations

Although the idea of balancing China seemed to surprise many in the United States and East Asia, it was very much the subtext of the George W. Bush administration's policies toward India. Bush began his first term convinced that China was not a strategic partner (as proclaimed by Bill Clinton in June 1998) but a potential peer competitor. He also was convinced that the United States must build a stronger partnership with India, the world's largest democracy and a potential balancer against China. Although Bush ended his second term with U.S.-China relations in reasonably healthy shape, he had successfully transformed the basis of the U.S. relationship with India by emphasizing the importance of building a new balance of power in Asia that favors freedom.

The explicit affirmation that the United States will assist the rise of India to great-power status provided a historically different basis for the ties between New Delhi and Washington. India's positive response to the new U.S. policy produced two important bilateral agreements. The first was the ten-year defense framework of May 2005 that opened the door for substantive defense collaboration—from arms sales to joint missions. The second was the civil nuclear initiative that ended India's prolonged atomic isolation and opened the door for both renewed international cooperation on civil nuclear energy and the integration of India into the global nonproliferation regime.

During the Bush years, both Washington and New Delhi were careful not to formally define their new partnership in terms of opposition to China. Nevertheless, Beijing was quick to see the defense and nuclear agreements as first steps toward a strategic partnership aimed at containing China. Although all three capitals know that a significant reordering of the relations among the three powers is some distance away, the U.S. declaration of a strategy to rebalance toward Asia has intensified the triangular dynamic among Washington, Beijing, and New Delhi. As the United States makes specific moves as part of the pivot and China responds with its own policy decisions, India can no longer ignore the consequences of its relations with the United States or China on the other country. New Delhi's

freedom to simultaneously deepen ties with both Washington and Beijing will increasingly be constrained amid the gathering tensions between the United States and China. U.S. rebalancing has made it more likely that the triangular dynamic among Washington, Beijing, and New Delhi will become more consequential in the near term.

India's Response

The Obama administration's rebalancing toward Asia has compelled New Delhi to think more clearly about the costs and benefits of a tight embrace with the United States. Motivated by concerns about China's growing assertiveness, U.S. willingness to strengthen India's strategic capabilities and support New Delhi's potential leadership role in Asia marks a significant moment in Indo-U.S. relations. Whereas for decades U.S. regional policies had constrained India's options in Asia, Washington is now offering to expand New Delhi's room for strategic maneuvering.

The realists in New Delhi's policy establishment have no problem recognizing the geopolitical significance of the U.S. pivot to Asia. They appreciate the possibility that the pivot could compel Beijing to be more reasonable toward India as China begins to focus on the U.S. military challenge from the east. The greater the U.S. pressure in the Pacific, the more likely that China would want to keep its southwestern frontiers tranquil. New Delhi's realists also understand that the gap in defense and strategic capabilities between India and China is widening in Beijing's favor. China's GDP is currently four times as large as that of India and its defense spending is nearly three and half times as large. India thus cannot merely rely on internal balancing to cope with China's rise; rather, the United States and its Asian allies must be central to any Indian strategy of external balancing.

Indian enthusiasm for U.S. rebalancing toward Asia, however, is tempered by a number of other considerations. For one, China is becoming an ever-larger economic partner for India, presenting New Delhi with the same dilemma that confronts others in the region. Like every other Asian state, India wants to benefit from China's economic growth but is deeply concerned about the country's growing military might. While recognizing the benefits of the U.S. pivot, the realists understand the dangers of provoking China's hostility. The realists also have to manage the domestic political consequences of a military alignment with the United States against China, which alarms foreign policy conservatives attached to the

idea of “strategic autonomy,” those on the left still enamored with the dream of building “Eastern solidarity against the West,” and the nativist right that resents being dragged into Asian geopolitics by Washington.

While responding cautiously to the U.S. pivot, New Delhi has steadily expanded defense cooperation with the United States and deepened diplomatic engagement with U.S. allies and other leading actors in Asia. At the same time, it has sought to reassure Beijing that India will not become a mere adjunct to the new U.S. rebalancing strategy toward Asia. Its future responses are likely to depend on the evolution of the ground situation and progress in India’s bilateral relations with China and the United States.

Adjustments to U.S. Rebalancing

The United States has made clear its political intentions to maintain its primacy in Asia. A strong and sustainable U.S. role in Asia is welcome in New Delhi, which knows that the regional powers, including India, are not in a position to balance China on their own. Yet India, like many other Asian nations, will not want to be seen as simply joining the U.S. bandwagon against China. Even when it was profoundly weak, Asia did not submit itself to the discipline of the Cold War. Leading nations of Asia, especially those outside the U.S. treaty system, will want to retain a certain freedom of action in coping with the changing U.S.-China dynamic.

If the United States understands the political logic of this approach, stemming from Asian countries’ domestic political considerations as well as from the strategic culture of the last few decades, Washington should attempt to bring a measure of sophistication to the articulation of the Asian pivot. Central to this is the proposition that the United States must not be seen as working “on” Asia, following a predetermined plan crafted in Washington, but rather as working “with” the Asian powers in devising a supple approach to balancing China’s power. By adopting this strategy, the United States could profitably encourage a number of security initiatives among Asian powers without having to put itself in the political lead on every single initiative in the region. This adjustment will not be easy, however, given the political style of the United States, where a noisy internal debate complicates the pursuit of a more nuanced approach to the articulation and execution of rebalancing.

The United States should be conscious of the fact that India will never accept a Sino-centric Asia. India has consistently sought to balance China through the means available to it, even when Beijing and Washington were

allied against the Soviet Union. U.S. recognition of the converging interests between New Delhi and Washington and of the fact that a strong India will automatically generate better conditions for balancing China provides the framework for a more sustainable strategic coordination between India and the United States in Asia. For it is in the United States' interest to allow and support a free play of India's natural instincts in the region.

Residual Indian Skepticism

As is the case elsewhere in Asia, there is much residual skepticism in India about U.S. rebalancing. While New Delhi sees the broad support from Republicans for the pivot, there are questions about the depth of consensus on the new U.S. policy toward China. The financial crisis in the United States, questions about the speed of the country's economic recovery, and the uncertain dynamics of American domestic politics all raise legitimate questions about the sustainability of the pivot. New Delhi also wonders if the economic interdependence between the United States and China, as well as Washington's need for Beijing's support on a range of regional and global issues, will limit a substantive U.S. response to China's strategic assertiveness. Further, New Delhi suspects that a more rapid shift in the distribution of power between Washington and Beijing in favor of the latter might encourage the United States to accommodate China rather than counter its potential dominance of the region. In such a scenario, India does not want to find itself too far out ahead of the United States in dealing with a rising China.

If the U.S. pivot to Asia is a work in progress, India's adaptation is likely to focus on strengthening the country's own strategic capabilities, bridging its growing gap with China in collaboration with Washington, avoiding provoking Beijing, and raising its own independent profile in Asia. India has walked this tightrope well so far; but the rope is long and the going could get tough for New Delhi if push comes to shove between Washington and Beijing. ♦